

2 Video Game Consoles

2.1 Sony PlayStation 3

Without a doubt, the most highly anticipated product in this generation of consoles was Sony's PlayStation 3 (PS3). The original PlayStation and the PlayStation 2 had already been mega-hits, and with Microsoft upping the ante with the Xbox 360, the world was ready for Sony to take it head-on.

And what a reply it was! Sony came out with what it regularly touted as a mini-supercomputer and its foray into the 'convergence box' – a central multimedia and computing device to replace all others in a household. The PlayStation 3 first launched in Japan on November 11, 2006, and sold 81,639 systems within 24 hours, according to Media Crate.

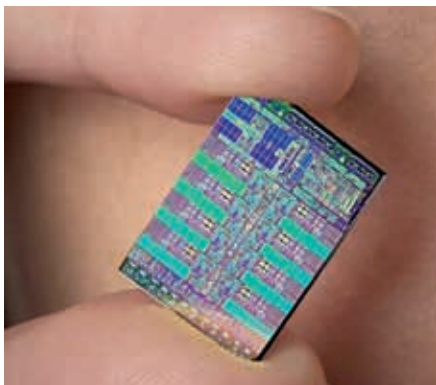
2.1.1 HARDWARE

Cell Processor

At the core of everything that the PS3 stands for is the awesome processor that was custom-built for it, dubbed the 'Cell Processor'.

The story goes that after launching the PS2, Sony executives wanted their next console to have the capability of outperforming the ever-increasing hardware of computers around it. The processor – the heart of any computing – was narrowed down as the one aspect to concentrate on and make it unbeatable.

The company then approached IBM, the world's leading makers and innovators of chips, to build a processor that would be two generations ahead of the PC processors prevalent at the time. IBM was glad to oblige, but asked for a little help. In 2000, an alliance called STI was formed between IBM, Sony Computer Entertainment and Toshiba, who together worked on the design of the Cell Broadband Engine Architecture (CBEA), commonly known as the Cell microprocessor. The first chip was tested in the STI Design Centre at Austin, Texas. And the first real application, of course, was in the PlayStation 3.



The PS3's heart can run eight processes in parallel, making it the fastest home-use processor on the planet. And hey, it's being used by scientist for super-computers too!